Putting the “I” in Entrepreneurial Identity: Self-Enclosure in Digital Ventures

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ABSTRACT

Entrepreneurial identity research has built rich accounts of how founders construct identity in relation to external audiences: customers, competitors, communities, and causes. Yet digital technologies have lowered barriers to contemporary entrepreneurial entry, weakening the discipline that once required entrepreneurs to verify their market prior to founding. I draw on grounded-theory analysis of 61 interviews with digital-era entrepreneurs to explore how identity emerges and stabilizes when that discipline weakens. The analysis identifies a self-referential identity orientation organized around the self, the *Individualist*, sustained through a process I call *entrepreneurial self-enclosure*. Individualists treat self-expression as the motivation for founding, alignment with the self as the measure of success, and an idealized self as the primary frame of reference. Post-organizational labor markets, cultural scripts of self-actualization, and digital affordances together enable the orientation. When weak market signals reach them, Individualist entrepreneurs reframe those signals as evidence of authenticity, freedom, or personal failing rather than as feedback about the venture. This study specifies a personal-level entrepreneurial identity prior typologies theorized but did not develop empirically, and identifies the conditions under which founding is decoupled from the foundational discipline of market opportunity verification.

INTRODUCTION

Founding a business has long been understood as a way to pursue one's own goals, dreams, and desires in work. A growing body of research in entrepreneurial identity has built on this premise, showing that how an entrepreneur answers "who I am" and "who I want to be" shapes how they build their venture (Baker and Powell, 2022; Powell and Baker, 2014; Grimes, 2018; Hoang and Gimeno, 2010; Mmbaga et al., 2020).[1] This work has shown that identity shapes the businesses entrepreneurs create (Fauchart and Gruber, 2011), their strategic responses to adversity (Powell and Baker, 2014; Zuzul and Tripsas, 2020), the opportunities they pursue (Mathias and Williams, 2017, 2018), and when and how they exit (DeTienne, 2010; Rouse, 2016). Another stream of related research has explored the situated processes through which entrepreneurial identity is constructed, sharpened, and sustained, e.g., through community co-construction (Crosina, 2024), feedback-driven idea and identity work (Grimes, 2018), dynamic founder-venture construals (Crosina et al., 2024), identity adoption within hybrid identity networks (Fenters et al., 2025), and authenticity work over time (O'Neil et al., 2022).

Notably, this growing literature has largely treated founding as an outward-facing act. Entrepreneurs are, by default, expected to identify an opportunity, imagine a customer, assess a market, mobilize resources, and organize a venture around some external object of pursuit (Shane and Venkataraman, 2000; Sarasvathy, 2001; Davidsson, 2015). Similarly, entrepreneurial identity research has given this outward orientation a social-identity vocabulary. For instance, Fauchart and Gruber (2011)'s influential typology positions founders as explicitly orienting toward customers,

[1] I use "entrepreneurial identity" throughout, following Radu-Lefebvre et al. (2021) and Crosina (2024). The term overlaps with "founder identity" (Fauchart and Gruber, 2011) but does not presuppose the scale or formality that "founder" may imply.

competitors, community, or society, and operationalizes founder identity at the relational and collective levels of Brewer and Gardner (1996)'s framework of self-representation, with implications for how they operate their ventures. The process stream of entrepreneurial identity similarly grounds identity in interactions with external referents, whether the industry signals of Zuzul and Tripsas (2020), the coworking community of Crosina (2024), or the external feedback that triggers Grimes (2018)'s identity work. This outward framing has held for good reason. Market verification works upstream of venture-building, disciplining what entrepreneurs decide to build and shaping whether the venture survives.

However, this widely held assumption that entrepreneurs maintain an overt outward market orientation as part of their identities becomes harder to defend as universal in the modern digital era, where barriers to entrepreneurial entry have lowered substantially. A growing share of contemporary entrepreneurship is inherently digital and takes place with the facilitation of online platform technology. Platforms like Shopify, Patreon, Substack, and YouTube, as well as many others, share an underlying logic: digital tools and platforms supply the potential customer reach, payment infrastructure, and operational backbone that entrepreneurs once had to assemble through formal capital, employees, or physical premises (Autio et al., 2018; von Briel et al., 2018; Nambisan, 2017). At the same time, cultural scripts of authenticity, passion, self-branding, and self-help expertise call on would-be entrepreneurs to treat self-expression as a legitimate basis for founding, as opposed to the verified existence of a substantive customer base with a need for their self-expressive offerings (Cameron et al., 2025; Sheehan, 2022; Waterhouse, 2024). Embedded in these scripts is an "if you build it, they will come" expectation that an audience matched to the self-expressive offering will materialize on its own. Solo and small-scale digital activity has grown rapidly under these conditions (U.S. Census Bureau, 2023, 2024), even as the financial returns sit systematically below those of paid employment (Åstebro et al., 2014; Fleming, 2017; Hamilton, 2000). What entrepreneurial identity research has not yet shown is how identity processes unfold in the midst of digital-era entrepreneurship, when the audience and market that usually anchor classical identity work can be deferred or are absent. These conditions raise two questions: how does entrepreneurial identity emerge and manifest when low entry costs and anticipated audiences make pre-founding market verification seemingly optional among digital-era ventures? And how might the personal level of the self become not merely a background motivation, but the organizing principle of the venture?

To investigate these questions, I draw on 61 in-depth, semi-structured interviews with contemporary digital entrepreneurs[2] (30 men and 31 women), examining the dimensions of their entrepreneurial identity and highlighting the relationships between those identities, their strategic behaviors, and their venture outcomes. Using grounded theory analysis, I trace how three broad structural conditions are reflected in the identity orientations that entrepreneurs develop and enact.

My findings identify a self-referential entrepreneurial identity I call the *Individualist*, distinguished from the outward-oriented types in prior typologies (Fauchart and Gruber, 2011) by three features: self-expression as primary motivation, alignment with the self as the metric of success, and an imagined idealized self as the primary frame of reference. The Individualist is not a static type but is enabled and sustained through a trajectory I lay out and term *entrepreneurial self-enclosure*, in which post-organizational displacement, cultural scripts of self-actualization, and digital affordances together make founding without market verification both possible and culturally encouraged. Within this process of self-enclosure there is a conspicuous decoupling from the foundational discipline of

[2]What counts as an "entrepreneur" varies across the management literature (Shane and Venkataraman, 2000; Davidsson, 2015; Hamilton, 2000). I take each participant at their self-identification as a digital-era entrepreneur operating a revenue-seeking venture, following the labor-force-status framing of Sørensen and Sharkey (2014) and Hwang and Phillips (2024), which treats those whose primary economic activity sits outside wage employment (starting a business, working as an independent professional, or contracting) as an entrepreneur.

external market opportunity verification, and a pattern exhibited by entrepreneurs of reframing weak market signals into information about authenticity, freedom, or personal inadequacy rather than into disconfirming information about venture strategy. Two extended cases of this trajectory as well as a negative-case show how the orientation may not crystallize for entrepreneurs who bring prior market-facing occupational socialization or where financial urgency interrupts the self-reinforcing loop.

By developing the Individualist orientation and the process of self-enclosure that sustains it, this study contributes to the literature on entrepreneurial identity, which has positioned founders as oriented outward, mapping their identities onto the relational and collective levels of Brewer and Gardner (1996)'s framework (Fauchart and Gruber, 2011; Crosina, 2024; Zuzul and Tripsas, 2020). I specify a self-enclosed, personal-level orientation, filling the gap that prior typologies theorized but did not fully develop empirically and that recent process-stream work has illuminated through related lines of inquiry (O'Neil et al., 2022; Crosina et al., 2024; Ivanycheva et al., 2024). Doing so also surfaces the decoupling of founding from the discipline of market opportunity verification, contributing to entrepreneurship opportunity research and the study of digital and post-organizational work by offering an identity-level mechanism for the participation-over-verification dynamic extant research traces as digital tools and platform technologies continue to lower barriers to entrepreneurship (Waterhouse, 2024; Cameron et al., 2025; Autio et al., 2018). This contribution also directly answers calls in the entrepreneurial identity literature to extend identity research into the digital world specifically and to empirically develop the personal level of self-representation (Mmbaga et al., 2020).

THEORETICAL BACKGROUND & FRAMEWORK

Entrepreneurial Identity Theory and External Orientation

Research on entrepreneurial identity has helped us understand that entrepreneurs differ in what founding means to them, which parts of the self become salient in their venture, and what kinds of action feel appropriate once an entrepreneurial identity is activated (Hoang and Gimeno, 2010; Powell and Baker, 2014; Mathias and Williams, 2017; Radu-Lefebvre et al., 2021). This line of scholarship builds on the identity-theory and social-identity-theory traditions in social psychology (Stryker and Burke, 2000; Ashforth, 2001; Hogg et al., 1995), converging on identity as the link between an individual's self-concept and the social world within which that individual is situated.

Applied to entrepreneurship, this body of work establishes *entrepreneurial identity* as the set of self-understandings, thoughts, and feelings salient to a person acting as founder of a venture (Cardon et al., 2009; Hoang and Gimeno, 2010; Williamson et al., 2022). Fauchart and Gruber's influential work in this area developed a typology of entrepreneurial identity on the basis of social motivation, self-evaluation, and the varying reference groups toward whom founders orient. They built on Brewer and Gardner (1996)'s three levels at which the self can be represented across social actors: the *personal* level is the self understood as a unique individual distinct from others, the *relational* level the self in connection to specific others, and the *collective* level the self as a member of a group. Fauchart and Gruber's typology mapped three pure types of founder identity orientations onto the relational and collective dimensions of Brewer's framework: Darwinians orient toward competitors and markets, Communitarians toward a community of users or peers, and Missionaries toward a cause. Each orientation shapes founders' initial strategic decisions about market segments, customer needs, and resources deployed, imprinting the venture with the founder's self-concept. Notably, within this typology the personal level was named as theoretically available but was not yet specified empirically.

Subsequent research has deepened these foundations and traced process accounts of entrepreneurial identity (Grimes, 2018; Zuzul and Tripsas, 2020; Crosina, 2024; Crosina et al., 2024). Yet even as this literature becomes more processual, this research tradition has consistently taken as given that entrepreneurs orient toward some external referent that supplies the raw material with which identity is enacted and tested. This *external opportunity-orientation premise* assumes that entrepreneurs build their identity by orienting toward some outside group whose response will help them verify their ventures are addressing a concrete market need.

Phrases like "exploring new opportunities," "commercializing and exploiting opportunities" (Cardon et al., 2009), and "the quintessential entrepreneurial behavior of opportunity selection" (Mathias and Williams, 2017) carry the premise forward in the very vocabulary used to describe entrepreneurial action. This framing derives from classical entrepreneurship theory, which defines the prototypical entrepreneur as someone who recognizes and seizes valuable market opportunities (Kirzner, 1983; Gartner, 1985; Shane and Venkataraman, 2000). Current definitions span discovery, creation, and effectuation perspectives (Venkataraman, 1997; Sarasvathy, 2001; Alvarez and Barney, 2007), but all retain what Shane (2003) call the *individual-opportunity nexus*: entrepreneurship remains tethered to some external process through which the entrepreneur learns what can become viable.

The Underdeveloped Personal Level

Recent evidence has begun to call the external opportunity-orientation premise into question, showing that entrepreneurs may identify primarily with the product or production process (Cardon et al., 2017; Mathias and Williams, 2018), with a valued social cause (Fauchart and Gruber, 2011; Sine and Lee, 2009), or with an idealized lifestyle the venture facilitates (Ivanycheva et al., 2024; Wry and York, 2017). A subset of this work documents specifically self-referential dynamics: entrepreneurs couple their self-concepts tightly to their ventures (Crosina et al., 2024), anchor identity claims in authenticity rather than market reception (O'Neil et al., 2022), and frame founding as a vehicle for personal development rather than market service (Baker and Powell, 2019; Brownell et al., 2025). Yet within Fauchart and Gruber (2011)'s typology the personal level itself, where the self serves as the entrepreneur's primary referent rather than the agent acting on an external one, remains undeveloped empirically. Communitarians and Missionaries orient externally by construction; Darwinians, who emphasize individual competitive success, also orient outward in practice toward competitors, markets, and performance metrics. Prior research did not develop the personal level for valid phenomenological reasons: settings that require capital, employees, or immediate customer demand pull the personal level toward competition, community, or cause (Powell and Baker, 2014).

Digital-Era Entrepreneurship Shifts the Landscape of Identity

However, three changes to the material and cultural conditions of founding now make personal-level identity formation both more feasible and more frequent for digital-era entrepreneurs. Digital affordances reduce the material cost of declaring oneself an entrepreneur, while cultural scripts framed around autonomy and self-actualization make self-as-entrepreneur a culturally available identity—and post-organizational labor markets push workers outside traditional employment, where they must cultivate identity work on their own. I examine each in turn.

Digital Affordances: You "Can" Start a Business. In earlier eras, business success depended on capital outlays, organizational growth, and outside funding, and ventures that failed to find paying customers also failed to persist. Contemporary digital affordances let entrepreneurs create an online presence, sell services, test content, assemble audiences, and present a business identity with little upfront capital and without a formal organization (Autio et al., 2018; Nambisan, 2017), altering when and whether market verification happens and making it possible for the identity claim "I am building this" to precede the market-oriented claim that "there is demand for this." Those same tools also make entrepreneurial spaces feel unsaturated: the absence of obvious gatekeepers and the visibility of novel customer niches can make the audience seem open and still waiting to be found (c.f. Micelotta et al., 2026), while crowdfunding and social media visibility blur the line between attention, affirmation, and market demand (Mollick, 2014; Pillemer et al., 2026). An entrepreneur may see others succeeding, create a public business identity, and infer demand without ever conducting market research.

Cultural Scripts: You "Should" Start a Business. The cultural meaning of self-employment has also shifted. Working for oneself was assembled in the United States between the 1970s and the 2000s as the canonical expression of the American Dream through identifiable actors and institutions, even as new-business-start rates declined steadily from the late 1970s onward (Waterhouse, 2024; Eberhart et al., 2025). Recent management and organizations work corroborates the contemporary transmission mechanism: platforms operate authenticity, passion, and self-expression as *neo-normative control* (Cameron et al., 2025); the passion-as-fulfillment script reproduces labor-market inequality (Cech, 2021); self-directed venturing has been institutionalized as policy-relevant "entrepreneurialism" (Eberhart et al., 2025); and the script is internalized at the individual level through personal-branding discourse, coaching ecosystems, and reframings of entrepreneurship as a liberal art or lifestyle pursuit (Vallas and Christin, 2018; Sheehan, 2022; Baker and Powell, 2019; Ivanycheva et al., 2024).

Post-organizational Labor Markets: You "Might as Well" Start a Business. The labor market itself has also shifted. Stable organizational employment of the kind that anchored mid-twentieth-century work has thinned over the past four decades, as corporations employ fewer people directly, labor fissures across contracting relations, and self-employment becomes one of the paths through which displaced or constrained workers manage risk (Davis, 2016; Weil, 2014; Hwang and Phillips, 2024); what was once a last-resort exit has become a more routine response (Eberhart et al., 2025; Dencker et al., 2021; Thébaud, 2015). The consequence for identity formation is that entrepreneurs cannot rely on the relational and material scaffolding organizational employment once supplied and must construct their own routines, relationships, places, and purposes to make precarious and personalized work identities viable (Petriglieri et al., 2019).

Together, the three conditions recast the external opportunity-orientation premise running through prior entrepreneurial identity research from a definitional given into an empirical question. Entrepreneurial identity research has shown how founders construct identity in relation to customers, competitors, communities, and causes, but the contemporary digital setting weakens each of those anchors. What entrepreneurs build their identity around once the anchors weaken is what this study examines.

METHODS

Research Design and Setting

Digital entrepreneurship is an extreme case (see Eisenhardt, 1989) for studying how structural conditions shape entrepreneurial identity, since the three conditions identified in the theory section are concentrated in this setting. By digital entrepreneurship I mean ventures that use digital technologies as primary infrastructure for customer reach, product delivery, and business operations (Autio et al., 2018; Nambisan, 2017).

I use constructivist grounded theory analysis (Charmaz, 2014; Glaser and Strauss, 1967; Edmondson and McManus, 2007), which permits iterative engagement with prior theory as the analysis develops. Phase 1 was inductive open coding. Phase 2 surfaced abductively a primary analytic dimension prior typologies could not accommodate, which led me to bring Brewer and Gardner (1996)'s three dimensions of self-representation in as a deductive coding scaffold. Phase 3 organized second-order categories into aggregate theoretical dimensions. Semi-structured interviews open access to entrepreneurs' own understandings of who they are, why they founded ventures, and how they relate to markets and customers (Charmaz, 2014).

Sample and Data Collection

I employed theoretical sampling (Charmaz, 2014; Glaser and Strauss, 1967), varying along three dimensions the emerging analysis showed were pertinent: gender (balanced to address prior all-male or gender-aggregated samples), industry (digital content creation and coaching, e-commerce, design, food and hospitality, technology services, consulting, and creative arts), and venture stage (ages two to eighteen, separating entry orientations from those that took shape, shifted, or weakened as ventures matured). As the analysis developed, I sought cases that would push on the emerging categories, including entrepreneurs whose accounts I thought might break the pattern. The final sample comprises 61 founders, 31 women and 30 men.

Recruitment proceeded in two waves, both screening for operation of a revenue-seeking digital-era venture, contactability through publicly listed channels, and English-language operation. The first wave (early 2023) drew from the public follower list of a major creative-entrepreneurship community (approximately 75,000 accounts) combined with a separate industry-list contact pool; the second wave (2024–2025) used stratified sampling within the same frame to pursue greater variation in industry, venture stage, and entrepreneur background and to test whether emerging categories held across entrepreneurs whose entry conditions differed from the first. Snowball referrals supplemented both waves, surfacing cases at the periphery of the frame, including entrepreneurs whose ventures had recently failed or who had stepped back from active operation. Included participants had founded or co-founded a venture, been the primary decision-maker, and been operating for at least one year, the last filter mitigating survivorship bias by ensuring enough history to display outcome heterogeneity (Brown et al., 1992). In line with this paper's treatment of entrepreneurship as a contextualized process of mobility, I set no revenue or scale threshold. Following Charmaz (2014) and Corbin and Strauss (2008), I treated saturation as a property of analytic categories rather than the population, continuing until new transcripts added only confirming detail. Table A1 (Appendix A) reports per-participant gender, identity type, broad industry, employment, venture age, and education.

The sample contains both positive and negative cases for the orientation I trace. Some entrepreneurs had every surface characteristic associated with self-enclosure (solo operation, online visibility, self-as-brand venture structure), yet oriented toward a community, a cause, or a customer problem rather than the self. Others began with self-expression as the organizing logic but later developed market-oriented practices after running into financial pressure. Reading those contrast cases against entrepreneurs who sustained a self-referential orientation across years of operation let me distinguish self-enclosure from solo work, creative work, platform use, or personality as a stable trait.

Interview Protocol

Interviews averaged approximately 60 minutes (range 35–95) and were conducted via video conferencing between January 2023 and May 2025; all were recorded with participant consent and transcribed verbatim, producing approximately 1,500 pages of transcript data. All recruitment, consent, and interviewing procedures followed protocols approved by the Cornell University Institutional Review Board (Protocol # IRB0145584).All participant names are pseudonyms, and potentially identifying details (specific employer names, narrow industry categories, granular geography) have been generalized to protect confidentiality.

The protocol iterated as the research question sharpened. Earliest interviews used a narrower, life-history-oriented guide tracking the time before, during, and after founding; reflection on early transcripts and advisor conversations added probes about occupational alternatives, digital platforms, and venture evaluation. As Phase 2 coding (described below) surfaced Brewer and Gardner (1996)'s three dimensions as the analytic scaffold, the guide evolved to include aligned probes, stabilizing by the second wave into the seven-part structure described in Appendix B, with participant-specific probes added when prior interviews surfaced relevant patterns. This evolution is itself a form of analytic reflexivity (Charmaz, 2014): earlier and later interviews therefore probe somewhat different dimensions of the same phenomenon, which I flag so the depth of evidence across the corpus is visible. The seven-part guide probes the three theoretical dimensions of entrepreneurial identity (Brewer and Gardner, 1996; Fauchart and Gruber, 2011): motivation, self-evaluation, and frame of reference. The alignment was formalized during Phase 2 coding rather than imposed on participants. Outcome questions came near interview close, after rapport was in place.

Data Analysis

My analysis was iterative, proceeding through three phases of coding from first-order codes to second-order categories to aggregate theoretical dimensions (Gioia et al., 2013; Miles and Huberman, 1994). After the first cluster of transcripts I began open coding, returning to earlier transcripts each time the code structure shifted. Constant comparison across cases (Strauss and Corbin, 1998) guarded against findings that turned out to be artifacts of a small subset and kept me honest about whether each identity orientation was represented by multiple entrepreneurs across gender, industry, and venture stage. Whenever a category was supported by fewer than three independent cases I flagged it as preliminary, sought disconfirming evidence, and either kept or discarded it.

Phase 1: First-order coding. Initial coding was inductive and stayed close to entrepreneurs' own language; the first stable code set, emerging after roughly the first twenty transcripts, organized accounts around nine codes (passion, pragmatism, entrepreneurial identity, other identity, anti-entrepreneurial, positive affect, negative affect, pushed out, and outcomes), each anchored by concrete language. Positive affect, for example, was coded when entrepreneurs used markers including *excites*, *I like*, *love*, *energizes*, *motivates*, and *meaningful*. Two patterns the initial code set could not absorb became visible as coding progressed: entrepreneurs varied in whether they organized their accounts around themselves or around an external opportunity, and the self-organized further varied in whether the self-organization produced a sustained or struggling venture.

Phase 2: Second-order categorization. Through constant comparison I grouped first-order codes into second-order categories that captured each entrepreneur's underlying organizing principle. The most consequential analytic move emerged abductively rather than from prior theory: a primary dimension I labeled *self-versus-opportunity orientation*, with entrepreneurs organizing their accounts either around the expression and development of who they were (*self*) or around the recognition and pursuit of an external market opportunity (*opportunity*). I re-coded first-wave transcripts against this dimension; within the self-oriented cluster, further variation emerged across entrepreneurs who sustained the self-orientation, struggled with it, or later reorganized around a viable external opportunity. As the dimension stabilized, I built out a deductive scaffold drawing on Brewer and Gardner (1996)'s three dimensions and compared cases against Fauchart and Gruber (2011)'s established types, surfacing the cluster whose evaluative standard and frame of reference were the self rather than any external referent.

Phase 3: Theoretical dimensioning and mechanism development. I organized second-order categories into aggregate theoretical dimensions, tracing connections between entrepreneurs' post-organizational career histories, exposure to cultural scripts of self-actualization, and reliance on digital affordances. The analysis yielded the three-condition structural account and the concept of entrepreneurial self-enclosure developed in the Findings.

Outcome coding. I coded each venture along three outcome dimensions so the Findings could examine how identity orientation related to outcomes in this digital context: venture survival (still operating at interview; Gartner et al., 1999), financial sustainability (whether entrepreneurs described the venture as providing adequate financial support without external income), and customer growth (shrinking, maintained, growing gradually, or growing rapidly).

Across all three phases I kept analytical memos as the main device for tracking interpretive decisions (Charmaz, 2014): per-participant memos recorded which orientation labels applied, which quotes anchored each, and how the case sat relative to similarly-coded entrepreneurs, surfacing the boundary cases later coding rounds had to absorb. Negative-case analysis grounded the structural-mechanism claims developed in the Findings (Eisenhardt et al., 2016; Small and Calarco, 2022). Figure 1 displays the analytical pipeline from first-order codes through second-order themes to aggregate theoretical dimensions.

[Insert Figure 1 about here]

FINDINGS

Grounded-theory analysis surfaced a structurally enabled identity orientation I call the Individualist. Three identity features distinguish it from the external-market-opportunity-oriented types in prior typologies (Fauchart and Gruber, 2011; Brewer and Gardner, 1996): self-expression as motivation for entry, alignment as the metric of success, and the idealized self as frame of reference. I describe the orientation and the conspicuous absence of external market verification that follows from it, then trace the three contextual conditions and the self-reinforcing trajectory of *entrepreneurial self-enclosure* that produce it and hold it in place. Negative cases close the analysis.

The Individualist Entrepreneur: A Self-Referential Identity at the Personal Level

What emerged most consistently across my analysis was a distinct identity orientation that the established types of Darwinian, Communitarian, and Missionary (Fauchart and Gruber, 2011) could not fully accommodate. The entrepreneurs in this orientation narrated their ventures not by reference to customers, competitors, or community, but by reference to themselves. I term this orientation the Individualist. It corresponds empirically to the personal level of Brewer and Gardner (1996)'s social-identity framework, a level prior entrepreneurial-identity research has theorized but not developed empirically as an orientation in its own right. Three features distinguish the Individualist along the same dimensions used to distinguish the established types: self-expression as motivation for entry, alignment as the metric of success, and the idealized self as frame of reference. Where the established types orient toward an identifiable audience that anchors the venture, the Individualist substitutes the entrepreneur's own idealized self, with an unnamed audience whose arrival is taken on faith (see Table 1). The next three subsections walk through each dimension in turn.

[Insert Table 1 about here]

Self-Expression as Primary Motivation. The first feature that became apparent across Individualist accounts is a consistent orientation toward self-expression as the primary motivation for entry. These entrepreneurs described the founding act as an outward expression of who they are rather than as a response to demand they had detected in the world, with their accounts beginning from the question of what they wanted to do rather than what someone else needed.

An outdoor content creator captured this orientation: "I just want to keep doing the stuff that I love and making a living off of it" (Outdoor Content Creator, man, Individualist). Across the Individualist subsample, the self-expression motivation consistently preceded any consideration of market demand. Entrepreneurs narrated arriving at their ventures through introspection rather than opportunity discovery:

> *"What really lights me up from the inside? Because I've been going so hard, for so long, promoting other people's things. What's my thing? What do I want to do?" (Letterpress*

Stationer, woman, Individualist)

Another captured the same logic in shorter form: "This is just me just being me… I love this stuff that I think is so cool" (Collectibles Consultant, man, Individualist).

A consultant who had left organizational employment after a hostile corporate takeover narrated founding as a return to self rather than a move toward market opportunity: "Even from that young age, I've always been very in tune to my heart and my passions and my purpose… I made a promise to myself, I will never accept a job just because of money" (Leadership Development Consultant, man, Individualist). A YouTube creator articulated the orientation in explicitly instrumental language:

> *"It's a self-expressive benefit… I want people to like me. I want them to think that I'm creative. I want them to think I'm clever. And the dosages and appetite may vary." (YouTube Creator, man, Individualist)*

A graphic designer described the transition from organizational work to self-employment as a shift from serving others' visions to discovering his own: "I was using my creativity to do a lot of things for other people, and not so much for myself and exploring the things I want to say and the things I want to create" (Graphic Designer, man, Individualist). I return to his full case in the extended-cases subsection below.

Taken together, these accounts surfaced a consistent pattern across industries and gender, voiced by women in design, coaching, and healing and by men in content creation, photography, and consulting. The vocabulary of personal fulfillment, passion, and self-discovery preceded the language of market opportunity in entrepreneurs' narratives. The analytic implication is that the causal arrow most theories assume between the individual and a market opportunity runs the other way in Individualist accounts: the venture appears because the entrepreneur wanted to do something, not because the entrepreneur spotted something the market wanted. The question of whether anyone pays arrives later, if at all.

Alignment as Basis of Self-Evaluation. A second pattern, which I label alignment, concerns the basis on which Individualist entrepreneurs evaluate venture success: internal congruence rather than external benchmark. Individualists judged whether their venture was succeeding by comparing it to their own sense of who they are, not to revenue, market share, or peer benchmarks—the criterion is internal congruence and the test is whether the work "feels" like the self.

A residential renovator articulated this standard plainly: "I define success as doing something you love, but getting paid to do it. And in affording you a lifestyle that is comfortable" (Residential Renovator, man, Individualist). A productivity consultant and an HR consultant named the same internal-congruence test in turn:

> *"I like to have control. I like to be in command of my life. And when a situation comes across where I feel that's going to be compromised, regardless of the amount of money, I won't do it... We're not rich. We're middle class at best. But we're happy." (Productivity Consultant, man, Individualist)*

The same logic surfaced in the HR Consultant's account: "I do work that I love. It also makes enough income. So I can live a life that I think is worthy of living... self-worth does not come from validation from outside" (HR Consultant, woman, Individualist). A hybrid case extended the pattern into a Communitarian register without dislodging the internal evaluative referent:

> *"I'm not in it to make a million dollars in exit. I'm in it to make a living, meet interesting people and continue building relationships... I'm very much a 'what do I like' entrepreneur.*

I'm not about 'how much money can I make' entrepreneur." (Healthcare Consultant, man, Individualist-Communitarian hybrid)

A YouTube creator captured the logic in an analogy:

"I'd rather be Quentin Tarantino than Michael Bay... Michael Bay made the Transformer movies. His movies make a lot more money, but Quentin Tarantino movies make enough and he's cooler." (YouTube Creator, man, Individualist)

The same entrepreneur named the evaluative standard more precisely: "The minute you decide your identity isn't to be the biggest number, then you have a lot of flexibility to play with" (YouTube Creator, man, Individualist).

The identity-venture fusion reached its most extreme expression in the same entrepreneur whose entry quote opened the self-expression subsection. The Collectibles Consultant described refusing a venture capital acquisition offer:

"One of these VCs tried to buy me a few years ago... and he wanted my account. And I said, I can't do it. He said, why? I said, because this is me. I'm not selling you my account. This is me." (Collectibles Consultant, man, Individualist)

For this entrepreneur, selling the venture was literally selling the self. What these accounts converge on is a configuration in which self-expression as the primary motivation and alignment as the evaluative standard fuse the self and the venture into a single referent, with market-performance signals sitting outside the evaluative frame.

The Idealized Self as Frame of Reference. The third feature concerns the frame of reference Individualists adopt as founders—these entrepreneurs narrated the venture's purpose by reference to the person they wanted to become rather than to any specified external audience or market the venture serves. The frame that Darwinian, Communitarian, and Missionary entrepreneurs fill with customers, community members, or beneficiaries sat, for Individualists, around the entrepreneur's own projected self.

A wedding planner described the question that organized her shift: "I was asking myself those questions that I don't think I had asked before like, who do I want to be?" (Wedding Planner, woman, Individualist). A residential interior designer narrated the same shift as a creative awakening:

> *"It literally lit up my brain. And some weird creative side of me said, that's what I want to do... The creative side of me needed more training, so I took life drawing, photography, all of those things. I knew I was going to make the shift." (Residential Interior Designer, woman, Individualist)*

Other Individualist accounts named the moment of identity shift directly: "It was validating, of course, but it also was the point in time where I said. Yes, I'm not a project manager anymore. I'm a calligrapher" (Calligrapher, woman, Individualist). One renovator put the same orientation in active terms: "Instead of like adapting to the market. I create the market like people aren't doing creative stuff" (Residential Renovator, man, Individualist). Each account organizes the venture around a question about the entrepreneur's projected self rather than around a question about what someone outside the venture needs.

Taken together, the three features point to one structural pattern: the frame of reference is the self, not the audience. What looks from outside like a missing step is, from inside the orientation, no step at all, because a customer or external market was never the referent.

Across the broader sample, the Individualist orientation was the modal type (see Table 2); including hybrid configurations carrying Individualist elements, the broad-scope group covers a majority of the 61 entrepreneurs interviewed. This distribution is itself theoretically significant: the orientation existing identity theory has the hardest time accommodating, the personal level Fauchart and Gruber (2011) theorized but did not develop empirically, is the modal one in this digital-era sample.

[Insert Table 2 about here]

The Conspicuous Absence of External Market Verification

The three identity features above have a striking observable consequence—because alignment with the self is the basis of self-evaluation and the idealized self is the frame of reference, the venture lacks the practical hook to engage external market signals, producing a conspicuous absence of external market verification across the venture cycle. The absence of formal market research and the absent customer referent recorded in Table 1 are not bookkeeping omissions; they are features of an identity organized around the self rather than the market.

One digital graffiti artist anchors the pattern most cleanly: he had built 90,000 Instagram followers, but his online shop lost money each month, and he had not asked which of those followers would pay what for which pieces. Asked why he did the work, he was direct: "I do this purely for the love of it… There's no other real art form that speaks to how I feel. I want to creatively express myself" (Digital Artist, man, Individualist).

The follower count substituted for confirmed exchange: an audience presumed at the level of headcount and never specified at the level of paying transaction. He had not discovered or verified an opportunity, no paying customers had appeared, yet he performed entrepreneurship, sustained it through digital infrastructure, and experienced it as meaningful. The market relationship that would ordinarily confirm or disconfirm the venture never formed.

In stark contrast, entrepreneurs of other identity types did external-validation work the Individualists conspicuously skipped. A Darwinian entrepreneur organized his narrative around demand-scanning:

> *"I always understood the pain principle. You want to sell pain pills, not vitamin pills. Anything that you can help someone, lose weight, get laid or get paid, you will always make money." (Podcaster, man, Darwinian)*

A Communitarian entrepreneur flipped the Individualist account, narrating the venture as a response to verified demand: "Brides are begging me. They're like, 'I'll pay. Take my money' because they were having a hard time finding other florists" (Event Florist, woman, Communitarian). A second Communitarian entrepreneur articulated explicit market positioning:

> *"I want to be in the middle. Most fabricators either are builder commercial, or they are high end luxury, nothing in between… I started to get builders that wanted to contact us. Commercial Linkedin has been great." (Stone Fabricator, man, Communitarian)*

Across all three contrast types, including the Missionary (whose referent in Fauchart and Gruber (2011)'s typology is a cause or beneficiary collective), each non-Individualist named an external referent (demand, community segment, cause) against which the venture is measured. The Individualists are not doing equivalent work.

These findings highlight what the personal level of Brewer and Gardner (1996)'s framework looks like under digital conditions: an orientation under which ventures form without external market verification, because market signals never enter the orientation's frame. What makes such a self-referential orientation stabilizable in the first place is the question my analysis next takes up. Three contextual conditions in entrepreneurs' accounts answer it.

Conditions of Emergence: Three Contextual Features in Entrepreneurs' Accounts

Across the interviews, three contextual features recurred with enough regularity in entrepreneurs' accounts to warrant attention. A post-organizational labor market in which stable employment has eroded came first. Cultural scripts of self-actualization that frame founding as authentic expression came second. Digital affordances that lower the material cost of founding (to a point where market viability is no longer a structural prerequisite) came third. The three sub-subsections that follow read each in turn through entrepreneurs' own accounts. Table 3 lists representative quotes for each of these conditions.

[Insert Table 3 about here]

Post-Organizational Labor-Market Push. The condition entrepreneurs most often named first was the post-organizational labor market itself. They narrated entry as a movement out of organizational employment rather than an entrepreneurial aspiration, with positions eliminated and careers foreclosed by circumstances beyond their control. The mobility framing of Sørensen and Sharkey (2014), extended by Hwang and Phillips (2024), reads these accounts as describing what organizational options remain rather than what opportunities entrepreneurs identified, against a backdrop of disaggregated employment (Davis, 2016).

Consider, for example, a holistic health practitioner who had left a subcontracted, benefits-free role in physiotherapy:

"I'm doing this out of necessity, because the skills that I went to university for... if somebody

said, hey, we have this full time job with benefits that you could use your training in, and you can still have the flexibility you need as a single parent, I would leave it all behind for that." (Holistic Practitioner, woman, Individualist)

The venture, on this account, was what the labor market left open.

A residential interior designer, repeatedly laid off by small firms that described her work as excellent but could not keep her on staff, narrated the endpoint matter-of-factly:

"I worked part time in interior design, but I kept getting laid off because I was working for other small businesses… On Wednesday she told me I was gonna have a job, by Friday I was let go. It was always like, '[name], you're awesome. You do such great work. I just can't afford you.' So I opened up my own shop." (Residential Interior Designer, woman, Individualist)

Founding here appears to be the leftover, rather than the voluntarily chosen path.

Notably, the post-organizational push was not unique to Individualists. A wedding coordinator with a Darwinian-Communitarian hybrid orientation narrated the same trajectory of organizational exits catalyzed by structural events outside her control:

"I just always got fired from a job… I think, what, second time I ended up getting fired, and the other time the people were so happy for me to leave, they were like bye, thank you. Which is essentially being pushed out." (Wedding Coordinator, woman, Darwinian-Communitarian)

As such, the push is not unique to Individualists. It is a shared entry condition rather than a sufficient cause. What my analysis suggests the push does, in combination with the two conditions that follow, is remove the organizational anchor that would otherwise orient an entrepreneur toward markets or communities. Whether self-referential orientation follows turns on what conditions the entrepreneur additionally encounters and internalizes, as reflected in their narratives.

Cultural Scripts of Self-Actualization. Beyond the post-organizational push, a second feature emerged in many entrepreneurs' accounts: a cultural narrative that makes self-directed work feel purposeful. The striking feature of their accounts is not that they absorbed the cultural scripts of self-actualization but that they named them as scripts, recognizing the vocabulary they organize their ventures around as externally transmitted.

An outdoor content creator reflected on his own organizing logic:

> *"My why was I just want to do something I'm passionate about and doing something I love, because that's what you get told, you know, all growing up is you want to do something you love because then you never work a day in your life. As cliché as that sounds, that's literally what I get to do." (Outdoor Content Creator, man, Individualist)*

He named the passion script as a cliché he had internalized anyway, the experience Cameron et al. (2025) characterizes as neo-normative control, in which authenticity norms are felt as the worker's own preferences rather than as constraint.

Several entrepreneurs named the figures and media who supplied the template:

> *"Your Amy Porterfield, Marie Forleo, Jenna Kutcher. These were the people that you listen to on podcasts, and you pick one or two of them, and you do just what they say, because there's no other business teaching. There's no protocol for this. So you're just learning from the people who have already proven that they can do it. And then over time you start buying their courses." (Leadership Coach, woman, Individualist-Darwinian hybrid)*

The coaching ecosystem Sheehan (2022) describes fills the institutional gap left by the post-organizational push. Entrepreneurs without formal business education had no alternative protocol; the coaches built large followings by teaching entrepreneurship as authentic self-expression and personal brand, and the script my data show Individualist entrepreneurs internalizing tracks that template closely. The script is not merely absorbed but actively sought out by people who have no other on-ramp. I return to this leadership coach in the negative-case subsection; her second venture (web design) illustrates how a hybrid entrepreneur adopts market orientation instrumentally when the primary Individualist venture fails to generate revenue.

A third pattern recurred across multiple accounts. The entrepreneur and the commercial offering became indistinguishable in a kind of self-as-brand formulation. A photographer, asked whether she could ever sell her business, replied:

> *"It is me. I am the secret sauce. I am my business. I am so, to sell that? Probably not. Yeah, because I couldn't sell my name." (Photographer, woman, Individualist)*

The "I am my business" formulation recurred with enough regularity to constitute a pattern, not an outlier. When the entrepreneur treats the self and the venture as a single thing, market disconfirmation reads as an attack on the self, and the self-reinforcing loop later subsections describe draws much of its persistence from this fusion.

The temporal specificity of these scripts matters for interpretation. A leadership development consultant in his mid-forties observed that the passion-and-purpose vocabulary organizing his work was not available as an entrepreneurial framework when he was in school:

> *"I've always been very in tune to my heart and my passions and my purpose, very popular stuff now, but I'm 44. So I was in high school, 92 to 96. No one was talking about that stuff at that point." (Leadership Development Consultant, man, Individualist)*

The cultural scripts are not a permanent feature historically but reflect a more recent development; an individual operating in the 1990s may not have encountered this framework as a legitimate organizing principle for entrepreneurship. The Individualist orientation's prevalence in my sample may then in part be a function of when these entrepreneurs entered the labor market, during the period in which digital platform tools and self-actualization discourse reached their current institutional density (Sheehan, 2022; Waterhouse, 2024).

Digital Affordances and the Weakening of the Market-Entry Filter. The third feature emerged at the level of material infrastructure. The platforms, subscription tools, and low-cost production infrastructure of the contemporary digital economy weaken the economic filter that previously largely required entrepreneurs to confront market viability in order to sustain a venture (Autio et al., 2018; Nambisan, 2017; von Briel et al., 2018). Crowdfunding and direct-to-customer platforms further reduce the gatekeeping role that formal capital providers, like venture capitalists, bank officers, and SBA lenders, once played as ex ante market verifiers (Mollick, 2014).

A community educator made the low-cost argument explicit:

> *"Barrier to entry is really low for a lot of businesses. Any service based business, I mean, what's your barrier to entry? You got to have a logo and a Wix website. That's it. Some of these people can just spin up a Facebook page for their business. And that's it. So yeah, barrier to entry is really low." (Community Educator, man, Darwinian)*

A calligrapher who described social media as the enabling infrastructure for her entire venture made the same point:

> *"I would not have my business if it wasn't for social media point blank… it's free. So that's my free marketing… I would have to invest so much more money to have this business upfront that a lot of people maybe wouldn't have even taken the jump into doing." (Calligrapher, woman, Individualist)*

These accounts reflect the founding-threshold observation that runs through the digital entrepreneurship literature (Davis, 2016; Nambisan, 2017). When digital infrastructure is cheap, prior market verification stops being (seen as) materially necessary. If starting a venture costs no more than a Facebook page, the economic signal that would otherwise force market engagement (namely the need for revenue large enough to cover capital costs) no longer fires at entry.

Digital affordances were not only infrastructure in entrepreneurs' accounts. They were also a cultural environment in which entrepreneurs saw entrepreneurship modeled, turning an abstract possibility into a model someone could watch, copy, and adjust. A wedding planner described the moment she encountered a visible model of the kind of work she eventually built:

> *"When I started seeing other friends do it, I used to think I would never be cut out for that... I don't think I would have had the courage to start a business if I hadn't gone through the grad program at the bank." (Wedding Planner, woman, Individualist)*

The emotional register matters as much as the informational content here. Doubt, comparison, and the slow recoding of self-employment as a life one could occupy all sit inside her account. However, the digital infrastructure allowed her to see others doing it initially before she learned how to herself. A consultant building an online course business made the same logic explicit:

> *"We've got people that we follow online, and we don't know them, and again they're anonymous to us, aren't they, but it proves that it can be done; and therefore, if it can be done, why can I not do it if you just got to find the right formula." (Network Marketing Coach, woman, Individualist-Darwinian hybrid)*

Digitally-enabled examples matter structurally. Without a mentor or colleague as her model, the visible presence of strangers online substitutes in a digital version of the *hope labor* Kuehn and Corrigan (2013) describe, where platform metrics stand in for paying-market engagement without commercial exchange. Material infrastructure takes the cost filter off entry, and the cultural environment makes self-organized work an observable life model. Combined with the post-organizational push, these conditions contribute to some would-be entrepreneurs viewing founding as an attractive option, often without market confrontation.

The Self-Reinforcing Trajectory of Entrepreneurial Self-Enclosure

The three conditions above enable entry into a self-referential orientation. What my analysis suggests holds the orientation in place after entry is a self-reinforcing trajectory I call *entrepreneurial self-enclosure*: a dynamic in which weak market signals are absorbed back into identity rather than redirecting the venture outward, and through which the structural conditions, the identity orientation, and the cognitive defenses that protect it cycle through one another over time (see Figure 2). The remainder of this subsection traces the trajectory empirically, beginning with the outcome distribution it produces, then the cognitive defenses that reframe weak outcomes into features of the orientation, and finally two extended cases that walk the trajectory end-to-end.

[Insert Figure 2 about here]

Outcomes Across the Sample. Turning to venture outcomes, what my analysis revealed was a concentrated rather than uniform distribution. Self-enclosure does not predict failure across the board. Across the 24 pure Individualists, the pattern that emerged was bimodal. 7 (29%) reach revenue-supported scaling, with the venture supporting the entrepreneur's livelihood and showing further growth; 2 (8%) sit in a stable, solvent middle, covering livelihood without scaling further; and 15 (63%) operate sub-revenue, producing too little to support the entrepreneur without outside income (see Table 2). Including the 9 hybrid configurations carrying Individualist elements, the broad-scope Individualist group of 33 entrepreneurs distributes across these three tiers at 30%, 21%, and 48%, respectively. The sub-revenue tier names a position in which entrepreneurs rely on spousal income, day jobs, or prior savings to make ends meet. By contrast, the non-Individualist entrepreneurs distribute more evenly across the three tiers (36% revenue-supported scaling, 32% stable/solvent, 32% sub-revenue). The pure Individualist distribution is notable for its hollow middle.

This bimodal pattern is consistent with the self-referential orientation my analysis surfaced above. Because Individualists organize ventures around the entrepreneur's own desired self rather than around demand they have identified, the venture usually either finds a paying audience whose tastes happen to match the self the entrepreneur is expressing, or it does not. Without an external market signal to incrementally redirect the venture toward a steadier customer flow, there is no mechanism that produces the middle outcome non-Individualists more often occupy.

When the orientation does not read market signals as feedback, the venture has no built-in mechanism to redirect toward market verification when revenue lags. One photographer captured the structural ceiling that self-as-product creates: "It is like the glass ceiling of doing this profession where I am the service and the product" (Outdoor Photographer, man, Individualist). A Communitarian candle maker articulated by contrast the explicit business-discipline vocabulary that self-enclosed entrepreneurs systematically lack: "Finance, marketing, product, and service delivery… those are the prongs that you have to have in a successful business… for it to be a true, sustainable business" (Candle Maker, woman, Communitarian). How Individualist entrepreneurs make sense of the resulting financial shortfalls is the subject of the next subsection.

Reframing as Self-Reinforcing Stabilization. What stood out in my analysis of the Individualist sub-revenue tier was the absence of any market-redirection response. The 63% of pure Individualists in this tier face a market gap that, in any market-oriented identity, would constitute a signal to revise pricing, audience, or product; instead, in their accounts, that signal is absorbed back into identity. Because entrepreneurs evaluate their work against internal criteria, the financial shortfalls that accumulate around a non-market venture are often attributed to personal inadequacy or justified as the costs of being internally authentic rather than to the structural dynamics described above. In those accounts, identity consolidates around the self rather than the market, and an ongoing layer of identity work reframes what could be experienced as precarity into a narrative of authentic choice.

The reframing layer surfaced repeatedly across Individualist accounts. It took several distinct forms in the data, each converting a market signal that would ordinarily prompt revision into a feature of the orientation. The Greeting Card Designer described her financial situation as an exercise of freedom rather than a constraint:

> *"I've had to live with financial instability and find ways to accept that as an entrepreneur. And that could be the price I pay. That also could be the freedom I have. Everything's how you look at it." (Greeting Card Designer, woman, Individualist)*

Identity-fidelity also produced anti-scaling commitments that bound the venture's growth potential to the entrepreneur's self-conception. The Letterpress Stationer reframed small scale as a cult-following design choice rather than a shortfall: "I want my own cult following. I don't want to wholesale… I want to keep that feel to it" (Letterpress Stationer, woman, Individualist).

A furniture designer narrated retiring a specific income threshold he had once held as the criterion of success in favor of a stability-and-family standard that no longer registered the gap:

> *"I never in my... early twenties I thought I would like. I'll make it once I'm making 6 figures. And... that truly, that was like the sign of success to me. And... any financial goal. When you hit it, you realize that the goalpost just moves... I have contended... success is to build a business that builds enough stability that I can comfortably support a family." (Furniture Designer, man, Individualist-Communitarian hybrid)*

An end-to-end online retailer reframed a foreclosed financial opportunity as evidence of identity-incompatible behavior rather than as a missed payoff: "I knew that, like I could buy domain names and resell them to people at scalper prices. But I'm not that person, so I let somebody else buy cars.com" (End-to-end Online Retailer, woman, Individualist). A network marketing coach reframed the obligation to work as a freely chosen flexibility rather than as economic necessity:

> *"I don't have to work if I don't want to. It doesn't give me a lifestyle to. I would, because I choose to... It's more flexibility, and having the time and money freedom to do what you choose to do rather than what you have to do." (Network Marketing Coach, woman, Darwinian-Individualist hybrid)*

The accounts vary, but my analysis surfaces two cognitive defenses these moves cluster into. The first absorbs cost signals as personal failing, keeping the problem inside the entrepreneur where market verification cannot reach it (the Greeting Card Designer's "price I pay"). The second reframes the absence of market scale as an identity-protective design choice (the Letterpress Stationer's "cult following"). Both leave the orientation undisturbed; entrepreneurs who explain the gap in these terms do not narrate a pivot toward market verification but re-anchor the orientation that produced the gap, an ongoing pattern David's full case below walks at length. Weak market outcomes are absorbed into identity rather than allowed to disconfirm it. The two cases that follow show the full trajectory in action.

The Trajectory in Action: Two Extended Cases. Two entrepreneurs in my sample walked the trajectory end to end, illustrating how the conditions, orientation, and reframing layers play out within a single life-history. Both accounts moved through the same four phases (post-organizational push, cultural-scripts encounter, digital affordances, outcomes-and-reframing) across different industries.

Sarah, a muralist, began her trajectory in the post-organizational labor market. She studied medieval history through eight years of college and entered a series of underpaid, precarious positions in museums and historic sites. Her boss made the field's structural compromise explicit: "you'll get ulcers, but everyone gets ulcers on the job." She looked at the colleagues whose lives appeared comfortable in those roles and observed: "the people I was seeing around me who were looking more comfortable while doing these jobs were people who had rich spouses." The institutional path her education had prepared her for was, in her account, materially incompatible with the kind of life she could afford to want. Her exit from museums was a movement out of an organizational sector that had become non-viable for someone in her circumstances rather than a movement toward an entrepreneurial vision.

The cultural-scripts encounter arrived next, mediated by Instagram and an open-studios event she happened upon:

> *"One of the turning points for me was seeing other women doing it… I saw people, and not all of them are doing it full time, but all of them were making money off of it… And I was so jealous of what their lives looked like, and I had been so jealous of watching people on Instagram who are self employed, and seeing that they got to build the jobs that they wanted and live the lives*

that they wanted to do things that they wanted to do and build things for themselves." (Sarah, Muralist, woman, Individualist)

The cultural-environment affordance Kuehn and Corrigan (2013) describe operates here through the visibility of peers Sarah named: "seeing other women doing it" makes the orientation legible as a life she could occupy. She did not just learn that muraling was a viable mode of self-employment. She saw an image of a life organized around self-directed work and recognized it as one she wanted to occupy. The digital-affordance condition followed quickly. She taught herself mural painting, built a website, and began selling work through social media.

Across Sarah's account, the three identity features took shape over the trajectory. Self-expression motivation appeared in her reframing of organizational work as a place where her judgment had been systematically ignored: "I'm so tired of building things for other people that I didn't agree to. I didn't get to choose. I don't have a say." Alignment appeared in her measurement of success against internal criteria rather than against any external benchmark: "I'm so happy being in charge of me." The idealized self as frame of reference appeared in the construction of a new self-concept around the muralist identity, "I started doing mockups for murals... I built my website," organized around the question of what kind of life she wanted to lead rather than around an audience analysis.

The conspicuous absence of external market verification followed: Sarah did no formal market research, did not segment potential clients by willingness to pay, and did not test the pricing structure her work could command before launching. The pricing pattern she described was, by her own account, governed by an internalized estimate of her worth rather than by an externally tested rate: "I just raised my prices because I was under charging um, and part of it because I was like, Well, that seems crazy. The anybody would pay me that amount for my art." She had been "very okay with not being paid well… very okay with not being paid my worth," and her later recalibration toward a market-rate price did not derive from market scanning but from a self-conscious decision to value her own work differently.

The outcomes-and-reframing phase brought the closing move. Sarah's venture had not scaled. By her own account, she had matched the salary she would have made at the museum, in gross revenue, in her first year. The constraint she had articulated as the foreclosure of organizational employment, "my point of pride… what my salary would have been at the museum, which was, let's be honest, thirty thousand," was reframed as a preference. The most explicit reframing arrived in the closing phase of her account:

> *"I screwed myself because now I can't go back to working for somebody else like there are a couple of people I would work for, but like it'd be a really specific situation, because I'm like I'm so happy being in charge of me." (Sarah, Muralist, woman, Individualist)*

The reframing move is precise. A constraint produced by a foreclosed labor market becomes "so happy being in charge of me." The phrasing "I screwed myself" acknowledges the structural irreversibility of the trajectory, and the second clause absorbs that irreversibility into the identity orientation rather than allowing it to count as a cost.

David, a graphic designer, walked the same four phases through a different industry. David spent a decade creating visual materials for a church as a staff designer. He came to feel "I was using my creativity to do a lot of things for other people, and not so much for myself and exploring the things I want to say and the things I want to create." The post-organizational push arrived through budget cuts and layoffs that eliminated his position. He had planned to "ease my way into a part-time position there" while building his own business, but the layoff foreclosed the gradual transition. The structural endpoint was the same as Sarah's. Founding was the leftover, not the chosen path.

The cultural-scripts encounter followed and was, in David's case, more explicitly mediated by the coaching ecosystem condition described in the cultural-scripts subsection above:

> *"A few people that I had followed that were either entrepreneurs, authors, some kind of creative entrepreneur, and hearing them talk about their experiences and realizing like, Oh, there's there's a lot more to this, and I need to kind of surround myself with enough of these people that seem to know what they're doing… and so that led into even some conferences that I ended up attending." (David, Graphic Designer, man, Individualist)*

The transmission mechanism Sheehan documents operates explicitly in David's account. He positioned himself inside the ecosystem of entrepreneurs-talking-about-being-entrepreneurs as the substitute for the formal business training he did not have. The digital-affordance condition appeared as the operating infrastructure of the venture itself, with website, Instagram, speaking engagements, and a subscription software stack, entirely solo. Across David's account, the three identity features took shape over the trajectory. Self-expression motivation came first. David framed the venture as creative work he could organize around his own questions rather than around a client's brief. Alignment came next. He named the evaluative standard explicitly:

> *"I want to be able to have a business that supports the kind of life I want to live… And that's really the success goal. It's am I living the kind of life that I want to live? Am I being able to have the experiences I want to have." (David, Graphic Designer, man, Individualist)*

He contrasted that standard with the market-performance standard he could have adopted:

"It's not always about let me just make as much money as I can." The idealized self as frame of reference appeared in the organizing question of the venture, which life does this support rather than which clients does this serve. The conspicuous absence of external market verification appeared in the operations themselves. Pricing and positioning were absent; he operated through platforms other creative entrepreneurs had collectively legitimated. His outcomes-and-reframing phase was the most explicit of any case in the sample:

> *"I don't want to go back into a situation where I have to work for somebody else, they're telling me when I can't do things. All that stuff sounds like death to me right at this point. I've experienced too much freedom." (David, Graphic Designer, man, Individualist)*

The reframing is precise. Organizational employment, the trajectory's structural starting point, is recoded as "death," and the precarity that occupies its place is recoded as "too much freedom." Across both industries, the structural pattern is the same: neither Sarah nor David arrived as an Individualist; both narrated the orientation as taking shape across the trajectory, and both closed by reframing the structural constraint as a personal preference. The next subsection takes up where this trajectory does not play out.

Negative Case Analysis

The robustness of the self-enclosure trajectory can be probed through cases that should have falsified it. I identify two such classes in the sample. The first contains cases where surface indicators predicted the orientation but the orientation did not appear. The second contains cases where the orientation appeared in modified form under specific conditions.

The cleanest negative case my analysis surfaced was a parenting coach who runs a solo digital venture from home, built during maternity leave, with herself as the primary product. By every surface indicator, including solo operation, digital-first model, and self-as-brand structure, she should be an Individualist. Yet her motivation was entirely external-referential: “The biggest high for me is seeing these parents who are so hopeless and so confused and so abandoned understand their kid” (Parenting Coach, woman, Missionary-Communitarian). Her solo structure was not identity-driven but an accident of institutional defunding and military relocation. The case demonstrates that solo operation and self-as-brand are not sufficient indicators of Individualist identity, which is distinguished instead by the referent of self-evaluation rather than the business structure.

Hybrid cases revealed the orientation in modified form. Among hybrid entrepreneurs, three Individualist-Darwinian hybrids retained self-expression motivation while developing market orientation over time. In each case, the catalytic event was a financial crisis that punctured the self-reinforcing cycle. The Leadership Coach, the same entrepreneur introduced in the cultural-scripts subsection above as the leadership coach naming the Amy Porterfield / Marie Forleo / Jenna Kutcher coaching ecosystem, described developing a copywriting and web-design business alongside her coaching practice. Her primary venture (leadership coaching) is Individualist. The secondary venture is Darwinian and explicitly instrumental: “I don’t have passion for it… I do it because I can do it in three hours and make $900” (Leadership Coach, woman, Individualist-Darwinian hybrid).

Market orientation was learned as instrumental survival, not internalized as identity: the same entrepreneur runs the primary Individualist venture and a secondary instrumental venture in parallel, adopting market orientation in the second without revising the orientation that organizes the first. Two Individualist-Communitarian hybrids carried self-expression and community orientation in parallel from the start; both had spent earlier careers in community-facing roles (teaching, counseling, social work), which supplied a relational vocabulary less visible in the pure Individualists’ accounts.

Taken together, these cases point to two boundary conditions for entrepreneurial self-enclosure. First, the trajectory appears most complete when the entrepreneur lacks prior occupational socialization in audience-facing work. Among the pure Individualist cases for whom prior-career data was elicited, none had spent the bulk of their prior career in audience-facing service work (teaching, social work, sales, nursing, or pastoral work), whereas the two Individualist-Communitarian hybrids whose orientations did not fully crystallize as Individualist had both come from precisely those occupational backgrounds. Across these cases, prior experience serving others creates a relational identity anchor that resists self-enclosure. Second, financial urgency can puncture the self-reinforcing cycle, but when it does, market orientation is adopted instrumentally rather than constitutively. The underlying identity orientation persists even when behavior shifts.

The negative cases also help rule out the most obvious alternative explanation, that Individualism is a stable personality trait rather than a structurally enabled trajectory. If the orientation were dispositional, it would be stable across contexts and resistant to external conditions. The data show otherwise: financial crises can puncture the orientation, prior occupational socialization can inhibit its formation, and the cultural scripts entrepreneurs invoke when narrating it are temporally specific, unavailable in their present form before the mid-2000s proliferation of entrepreneurial self-help media. The Individualist identity, on this reading, is not something entrepreneurs bring to ventures but something that crystallizes over the trajectory my findings trace.

DISCUSSION

This paper began with a question: How do entrepreneurs develop entrepreneurial identity when external, digital-era conditions allow for their external orientation toward a specified audience, market, or opportunity to be weak or absent? The answer developed here is entrepreneurial self-enclosure, a process in which post-organizational displacement, self-actualization scripts, and low-cost digital affordances let entrepreneurs organize a venture around the self, before any market verification has occurred, and through which reframing narratives absorb weak market signals back into their *Individualist* identity rather than redirecting the venture outward.

Contribution to Entrepreneurial Identity Theory

My primary contribution is to entrepreneurial and founder identity theory. Fauchart and Gruber (2011) established that entrepreneurial identities organize how founders define ventures, choose markets, and understand customers—an insight that remains central, and one the present study extends by specifying a self-referential entrepreneurial identity at the personal level of self-representation (Brewer and Gardner, 1996). The Individualist is not a Darwinian with weaker revenue but an orientation organized by a different referent altogether: the entrepreneur's own desired self.

My study complements recent process accounts of entrepreneurial identity (Grimes, 2018; Crosina, 2024; Crosina et al., 2024; O'Neil et al., 2022), but it pushes them further toward the self as referent as starting & ending point in their identity processes. Labor-market and cultural conditions help produce the orientation before any market encounter—the entrepreneur's own self then becomes the evaluative environment of the venture, the referent against which the entrepreneurial process is measured. Where research on pivots traces how external feedback can force entrepreneurs into idea-and-identity work, I trace how identity can stabilize before any such feedback has been granted authority.

The negative cases in my data sharpen this process claim—self-enclosure does not follow from solo operation, platform dependence, or self-as-brand venture form on their own but requires the entrepreneur's identity referent to settle inward, which prior audience-facing occupational experience, acute financial pressure, and hybrid identity carry-over can each disrupt.

Bounding the Concept

Self-enclosure is structurally enabled, not a personality disposition entrepreneurs bring to founding. It is not synonymous with solo entrepreneurship or lifestyle business (Ivanycheva et al., 2024; Baker and Powell, 2019), which describe organizational form and growth ambition; Individualists often want growing revenue, but anticipate it from an unspecified audience rather than from a specified market need. Self-enclosure is also distinct from necessity entrepreneurship as the field typically frames it. Dencker et al. (2021) recast necessity as a contextualized process, a move my conditions-and-process account parallels, but self-enclosure does not require economic necessity to operate: I find it among entrepreneurs who are economically secure and among those constrained out of stable employment.

The Individualist orientation is also not a relabeling of Fauchart and Gruber (2011)'s Missionary type. Missionaries operate at the collective level, turning outward to a cause and evaluating the venture by social impact; Individualists operate at the personal level, evaluating against alignment with the ideal self, with self and venture fused into a single referent. The contrast shows up most clearly when ventures fail: a Missionary whose venture never reaches society can still hold the cause as worthwhile because the cause sits outside the self, whereas an Individualist whose venture never finds a paying audience has nothing outside the self to fall back on.

Implications for Opportunity and Venture Formation Research

My findings have an initial implication for entrepreneurship research on opportunity. Foundational accounts define entrepreneurship around the nexus between enterprising individuals and opportunities (Venkataraman, 1997; Shane and Venkataraman, 2000). Later work has debated whether opportunities are discovered or created, whether they should be treated as objective or enacted, and how entrepreneurs evaluate them (Alvarez and Barney, 2007; Davidsson, 2015; Sarasvathy, 2001). My findings identify a case those debates do not yet account for: founding organized around the self before any opportunity (other than the opportunity to participate) has been externally verified. In the Individualist accounts, the absence of market validation is tied to the venture's referent. Entrepreneurs ask what lights them up, what life they want, what kind of self they are trying to become, and whether the venture remains aligned with that self—the audience is presumed, hoped for, or deferred, and market feedback lacks the interpretive authority it has in opportunity-oriented accounts.

What my Individualist founders are engaging with, in the sense Hwang and Phillips (2024) develop, is an opportunity to participate in the labor force on their own terms, not an opportunity to address a market gap they have identified and verified. An entrepreneur who walks this route crosses from organizational employment into self-directed work. The platforms they use then supply the tools, the metrics, and the modest revenue that sustain their work whether or not a paying audience ever materializes. The individual-opportunity nexus holds in settings where material conditions enforce market engagement—when the digital affordances I describe weaken that enforcement, founding without a verified opportunity becomes structurally viable. What the entrepreneur is engaging with at that point is no longer the discovery, evaluation, and exploitation of a market opportunity but participation in self-directed work, with the venture serving as the vehicle and weak revenue absorbed back into identity rather than treated as a signal to pivot.

Entrepreneurs have always acted under uncertainty, but what is new in the setting examined here is that venture infrastructure, public self-presentation, and entrepreneurial identity can be assembled at low cost before an opportunity is externally disciplined—the self can become the first durable object around which the venture is organized. This helps explain why population-level growth in business applications and nonemployer activity need not map neatly onto opportunity quality or growth intent (U.S. Census Bureau, 2023, 2024). Contemporary founding includes many projects in which nonpecuniary rewards, life design, and autonomy sit alongside, or ahead of, the pursuit of financial returns (Hamilton, 2000; Åstebro et al., 2014; Ivanycheva et al., 2024; Thébaud, 2015).

Implications for Post-Organizational and Digital Work

A second implication follows for research on digital and post-organizational work. Prior work has shown that independent workers manage precarious post-organizational identities through holding environments (Petriglieri et al., 2019), that platform conditions push workers to sell the self under autonomy framed as control (Cameron et al., 2025), and that cultural scripts of authenticity convert labor-market insecurity into projects of self-making (Sheehan, 2022; Waterhouse, 2024). This paper connects those insights to venture formation. The entrepreneurs in this study are not only independent workers managing identity after leaving organizations; they are also building ventures, however small or precarious, around a self that has become economically actionable largely due to emerging digital technologies. Where Petriglieri et al. (2019) treats purpose as part of the holding environment that makes precarious work viable, self-enclosure names what happens to identity formation when such scaffolding is structurally absent and self-expression itself becomes the purpose around which the venture is built.

My study also has implications for digital entrepreneurship research. I do not claim that digital affordances cause the Individualist orientation itself (Darwinian, Communitarian, Missionary, and hybrid founders also used digital tools), but they do weaken one disciplining threshold, specifically, the (traditionally advisable) requirement that an entrepreneur secure substantial capital, employees, premises, or market validation before becoming publicly entrepreneurial. This weakening makes self-referential founding more viable. For instance, a website, social media account, online shop, or creator profile can host an entrepreneurial identity while the market remains hypothetical, helping specify what is identity-distinctive about digital entrepreneurship. Digital tools do not just expand scale, speed, flexibility, or reach (Nambisan, 2017; Autio et al., 2018; von Briel et al., 2018). They also can reorder the sequence in which entrepreneurs meet the self and the market, letting the entrepreneur build their business around a curated self-concept before any audience arrives.

Additionally, digital platforms loosen the material feedback that would otherwise pass between producer and market. Pillemer et al. (2026) document one outcome of that loosening. Creators who do reach a substantial platform audience come to experience that audience as a deeply present force in their work, a constant interlocutor that reshapes what they make and how they make it. My entrepreneurs show a different outcome of the same underlying condition. A paying audience never arrives, and the self-referential loop runs anyway, kept going by cultural scripts that treat self-expression as “enough” and by digital tools that keep the venture materially viable whether or not anyone is on the other side of the work.

Conclusion

My findings highlight that a presumed external market orientation is not universal in contemporary digital-era entrepreneurship; the referent of entrepreneurship cannot be assumed in advance. Some entrepreneurs orient outward to customers, competitors, community, or cause; others orient inward, toward the self they want to express. The trajectory of entrepreneurial self-enclosure is a structurally enabled identity process in its own right, held in place by post-organizational labor markets, cultural scripts of self-actualization, and low-cost digital affordances acting in combination (Brewer and Gardner, 1996; Fauchart and Gruber, 2011). Those conditions show every sign of intensifying rather than receding (U.S. Census Bureau, 2023; Waterhouse, 2024). In documenting this configuration, the study answers Mmbaga et al. (2020)'s call to "move the study of identity to the digital world" and develops the personal level of self-representation that prior typologies left underdeveloped. As agentic AI and ever-cheaper digital infrastructure let solo founders operate ventures at scales once reserved for capitalized firms, the decoupling of founding from the foundational discipline of market opportunity verification will only intensify, and the Individualist orientation is unlikely to remain a peripheral case but a configuration entrepreneurial identity theory will increasingly need to take seriously.

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Table 1: Comparative Characteristics of Founder Identity Types

Dimension	**Darwinian**	**Communitarian**	**Missionary**	**Individualist**	**Individualist: Founder Voice**
Level of Self-Repr.	Relational	Collective	Collective	*Personal*	"I'm not just trying to monetize the shit and bounce." (Collectibles Consultant, M)
Basic Motivation	Wealth, competitive advantage	Community support, mutual benefit	Social impact, cause	Self-expression, fulfillment	"What really lights me up from the inside? ... What's my thing?" (Letterpress Stationer, W)
Basis of Evaluation	Performance metrics, revenue	Value to community	Degree of impact	Alignment with passions, ideal self	"I define success as doing something you love, but getting paid to do it." (Residential Renovator, M)
Frame of Reference	Competitors, customers	Community members, peers	Society, the public	Idealized self; *absent* customer referent	"I was asking myself... who do I want to be?" (Wedding Planner, W)
Opportunity Orientation	Market opportunity	Community need	Societal problem	*None*: opportunity to participate	"I was so naive... I literally thought I'm going to put my label on it and make money." (Fashion Designer, W)
Market Research	Formal & informal	Informal, community-embedded	Mission-driven scanning	*Absent*	"I see other people are doing it. Why not me?" (Calligrapher, W)
Organization	Employees, growth-oriented	Small team, relational	Mission-aligned team	*Solo*	"I realized I could... build this entirely on my own." (Productivity Consultant, M)
Prevalence	24.6% (n=15)	13.1% (n=8)	1.6% (n=1)	**39.3% (n=24)**	—

Note. Characterizations of the Darwinian, Communitarian, and Missionary types follow Fauchart and Gruber (2011). The Individualist column reports the orientation identified in this study, occupying the personal level of self-representation that Fauchart and Gruber's (2011) typology theorized but did not empirically develop. Italicized entries mark dimensions where the Individualist orientation departs from all three audience-oriented types. The Individualist: Founder Voice column presents verbatim interview excerpts illustrating each dimension (all quotes from Individualist founders; "Self-Repr." = Self-Representation). Within-row descriptors characterize Pure Individualists; the prevalence row includes hybrid Individualists (n=24 total). Hybrid types excluded from all other rows; see Appendix A for full distribution. M = man; W = woman.

Table 2: Distribution of Founder Identity Types

	Women	Men	Total	%
Pure Types				
Individualist	13	11	24	39.3
Darwinian	8	7	15	24.6
Communitarian	4	4	8	13.1
Missionary	0	1	1	1.6
Hybrid Types				
Darwinian-Individualist	4	3	7	11.5
Individualist-Communitarian	0	2	2	3.3
Darwinian-Communitarian	1	1	2	3.3
Communitarian-Missionary	1	1	2	3.3
Total	31	30	61	100.0

Note. $N = 61$ founders. Pure types reflect a single dominant identity orientation; hybrid types reflect comparable salience of two orientations in coding. Percentages may not sum to 100.0 due to rounding.

Table 3: Representative Quotes by Structural Condition

Structural Condition	**Founder**	**Representative Quote**
Post-Organizational Push	Holistic Practitioner (W, Ind.)	"I'm doing this out of necessity… if somebody said, hey, we have this full time job with benefits… I would leave it all behind for that."
	Residential Interior Designer (W, Ind.)	"I kept getting laid off… '[name], you're awesome. You do such great work. I just can't afford you.' So I opened up my own shop."
	Wedding Coordinator (W, Darw./Com.)	"I just always got fired from a job… essentially being pushed out."
Cultural Scripts of Self-Actualization	Outdoor Content Creator (M, Ind.)	"I just want to do something I'm passionate about… that's what you get told… As cliché as that sounds, that's literally what I get to do."
	Leadership Coach (W, Ind.-Darw.)	"Your Amy Porterfield, Marie Forleo, Jenna Kutcher… These were the people that you listen to on podcasts, and you pick one or two of them, and you do just what they say."
	Photographer (W, Ind.)	"It is me. I am the secret sauce. I am my business… I couldn't sell my name."
Digital Affordances	Community Educator (M, Darw.)	"Barrier to entry is really low… You got to have a logo and a Wix website. That's it."
	Calligrapher (W, Ind.)	"I would not have my business if it wasn't for social media point blank… it's free."
	Network Marketing Coach (W, Darw.-Ind.)	"We've got people that we follow online… it proves that it can be done… why can I not do it."

Note. W = woman; M = man. Ind. = Individualist; Com. = Communitarian; Darw. = Darwinian; Darw.-Ind. = Darwinian-Individualist hybrid. Selected for theoretical representativeness and empirical vividness. The Communitarian quote in the Post-Organizational Push row demonstrates that the push condition operates across identity types, not only among Individualists. Additional quotes appear in the text. Full quote matrices available upon request, subject to IRB-approved confidentiality protections.

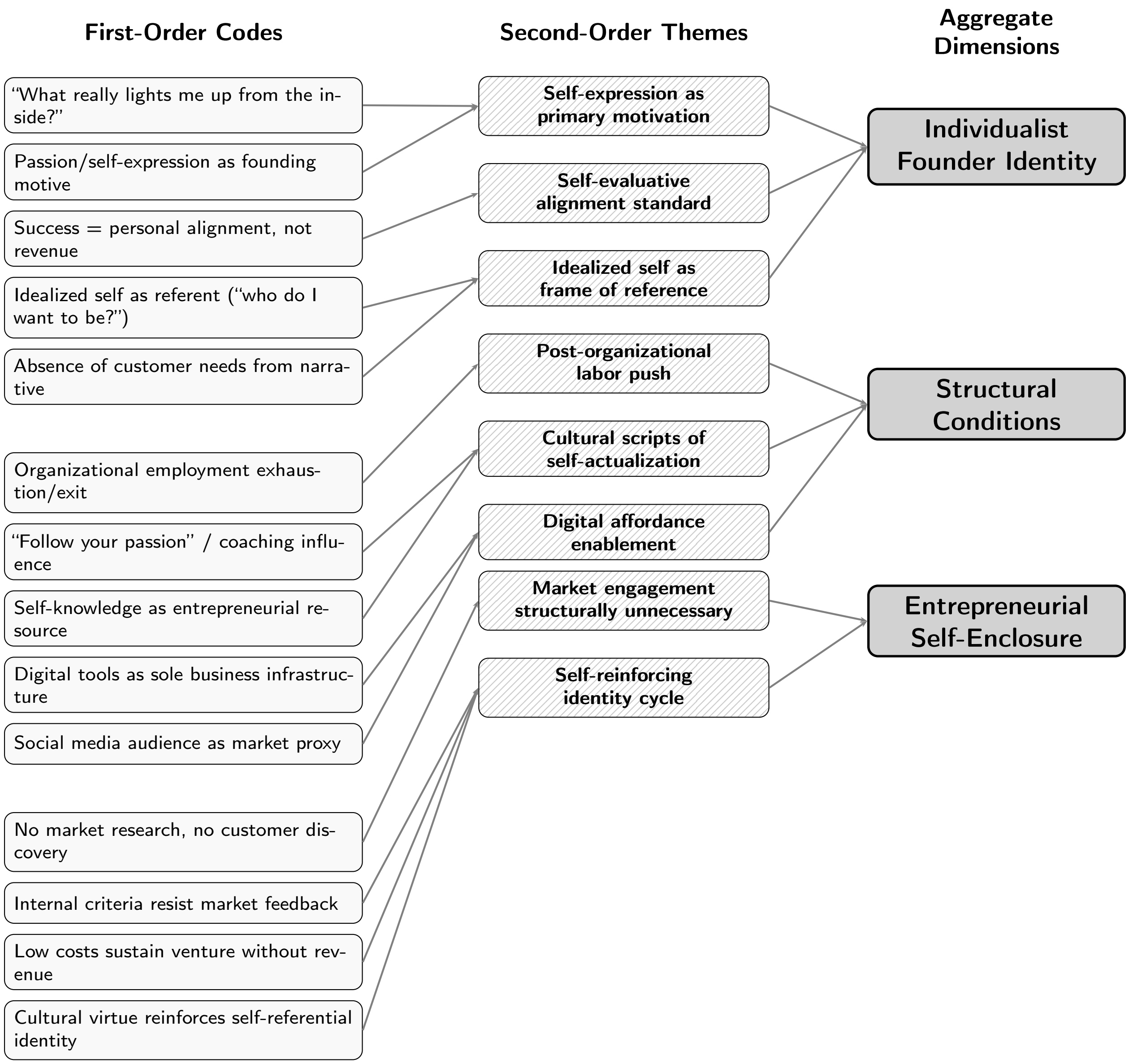

Figure 1: Data Structure: From First-Order Codes to Theoretical Dimensions. Codes derived inductively from 61 founder interviews using Charmaz (2006) constructivist grounded theory. Patterned cells denote second-order themes; solid-fill cells denote aggregate dimensions.

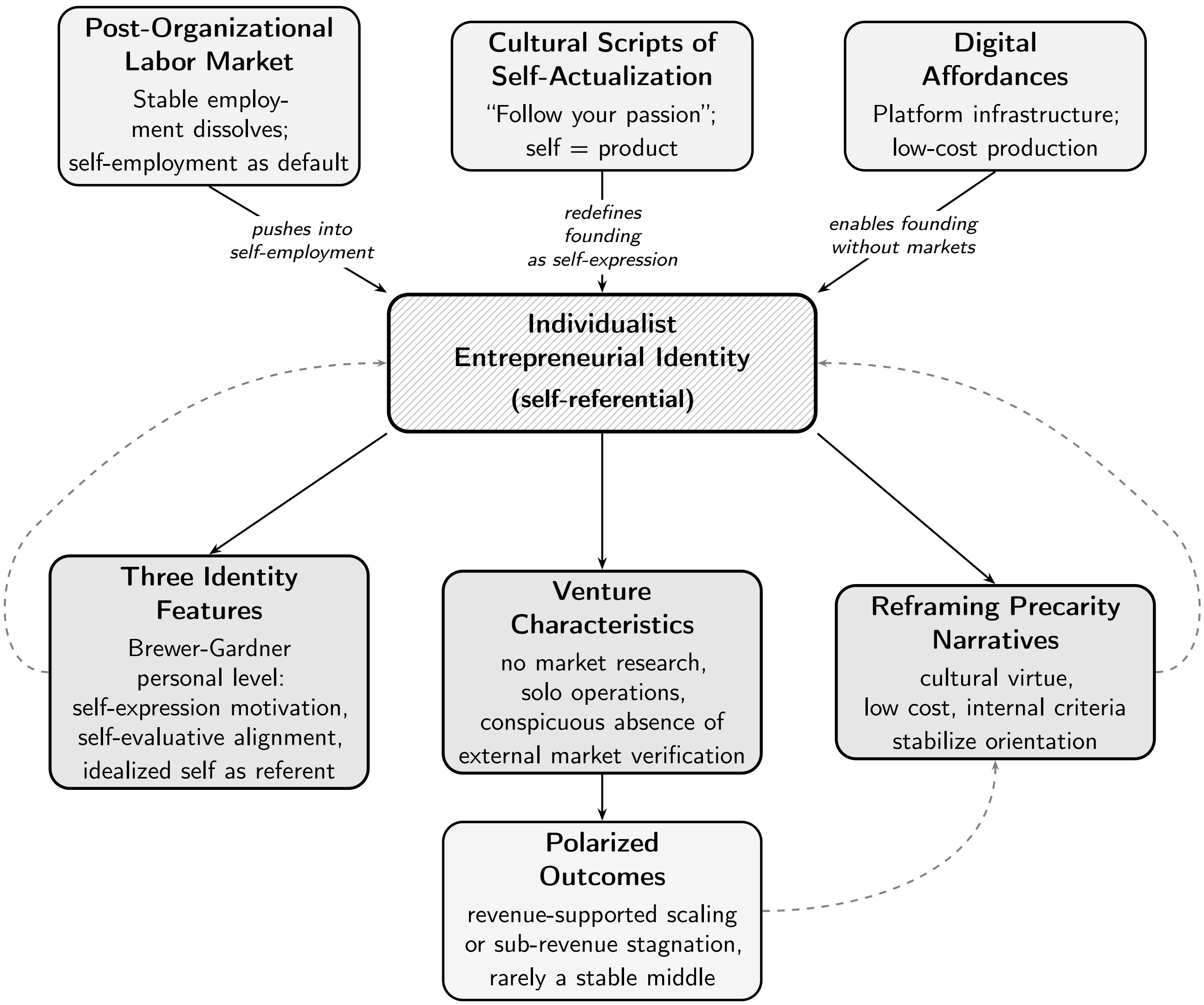

Figure 2: Emergent model of entrepreneurial self-enclosure as a structural system. Three contextual conditions appear in interviewees' accounts as the structural setting within which a self-referential Individualist identity orientation emerges. Three downstream consequences—identity features, venture characteristics (including the conspicuous absence of external market verification), and reframing precarity narratives—stabilize the orientation via a self-reinforcing feedback loop. Outcomes polarize between revenue-supported scaling and sub-revenue stagnation. For the sub-revenue subset, outcomes feed back into reframing narratives, closing the loop without market strategy reorientation. Arrows represent structural conditions and self-reinforcing dynamics observed across entrepreneurs' accounts, not tested causal paths.

Appendix A: Sample Characteristics

Table A1

ID	Business Description	Gender	Identity Type	Broad Industry	Emp.?	Vent. Age	Educ.
Panel A: Men (n = 30)							
M01	Digital Marketer	M	Darw.	Marketing	Yes	10	Some coll.
M02	Lead. Dev. Consult.	M	Ind.	Prof. Svcs.	No	12	Grad.
M03	Metal Sculptor	M	Darw./Ind.	Arts/Ent.	Yes	3	BA/BS
M04	Aerospace Engineer	M	Darw./Ind.	Tech/Eng.	Yes	4	Some coll.
M05	YouTube Creator	M	Ind.	Media/Content	Yes	10	Grad.
M06	Healthcare Consultant	M	Ind./Com.	Healthcare	No	10	BA/BS
M07	Studio Photographer	M	Ind.	Arts/Ent.	No	11	BA/BS
M08	Event Designer	M	Darw.	Prof. Svcs.	Yes	15	Grad.
M09	Graphic Designer	M	Ind.	Arts/Ent.	No	6	BA/BS
M10	Travel Educator	M	Com.	Educ./Coaching	No	7	BA/BS
M11	Property Manager	M	Com.	Real Estate	Yes	12	Some coll.
M12	Lettering Artist	M	Darw.	Arts/Ent.	Yes	10	BA/BS
M13	Collectibles Consultant	M	Ind.	E-comm.	No	12	BA/BS
M14	Productivity Consultant	M	Ind.	Prof. Svcs.	Yes	13	HS
M15	YouTube Creator	M	Ind.	Media/Content	No	3	BA/BS
M16	Community Educator	M	Darw.	Educ./Coaching	Yes	9	BA/BS
M17	Residential Renovator	M	Ind.	Trades/Const.	Yes	4	Some coll.
M18	Real Estate Agent	M	Miss.	Real Estate	No	4	BA/BS
M19	Stone Fabricator	M	Com.	Constr.	Yes	4	N/S
M20	Digital Artist	M	Ind.	Arts/Ent.	No	5	N/S
M21	Lifestyle Influencer	M	Com./Darw.	Media/Content	No	10	HS
M22	Software Developer	M	Com./Miss.	Tech/Eng.	No	6	BA/BS
M23	Outdoor Photographer	M	Ind.	Arts/Ent.	No	15	Some coll.
M24	Wellness Practitioner	M	Darw.	Health/Wellness	Yes	8	BA/BS
M25	Outdoor Content Creator	M	Ind.	Media/Content	No	7	HS
M26	Com. Photographer	M	Darw./Ind.	Arts/Ent.	Yes	11	BA/BS
M27	Online Retailer	M	Darw.	Retail	Yes	18	BA/BS
M28	Online Educator	M	Com.	Educ./Coaching	No	5	BA/BS
M29	Podcaster	M	Darw.	Media/Content	No	10	Some coll.
M30	Furniture Designer	M	Com./Ind.	Arts/Ent.	No	8	BA/BS
Panel B: Women (n = 31)							
W01	Muralist	W	Ind.	Arts/Ent.	No	3	Grad.
W02	E-commerce Consultant	W	Darw.	Prof. Svcs.	Yes	5	Some coll.
W03	Event Florist	W	Com.	Event Svcs.	Yes	8	Grad.
W04	Letterpress Stationer	W	Ind.	Arts/Ent.	No	9	BA/BS

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Sample Characteristics, continued

ID	Business Description	Gender	Identity Type	Broad Industry	Emp.?	Vent. Age	Educ.
W05	Online Retailer	W	Ind.	E-comm.	Yes	9	Grad.
W06	Photographer (Ind.)	W	Ind.	Arts/Ent.	No	11	Grad.
W07	Network Mktg. Coach	W	Darw./Ind.	Prof. Svcs.	No	4	Grad.
W08	Web/Graphic Designer	W	Com.	Arts/Ent.	Yes	5	BA/BS
W09	Candle Maker	W	Com.	Manuf.	Yes	15	Grad.
W10	Legal Service Provider	W	Darw.	Prof. Svcs.	Yes	6	JD
W11	Greeting Card Designer	W	Ind.	Arts/Ent.	No	3	Grad.
W12	Artisanal Goods Maker	W	Darw.	Arts/Ent.	No	18	BA/BS
W13	Copywriter	W	Ind.	Prof. Svcs.	No	2	BA/BS
W14	Content Writer	W	Darw.	Prof. Svcs.	No	3	BA/BS
W15	Parenting Coach	W	Miss./Com.	Educ./Coaching	Yes	12	BA/BS
W16	Com. Interior Designer	W	Darw.	Prof. Svcs.	Yes	9	BA/BS
W17	Marketing Educator	W	Darw.	Educ./Coaching	Yes	4	Grad.
W18	Fashion Designer	W	Ind./Darw.	Retail	Yes	10	BA/BS
W19	Calligrapher	W	Ind.	Arts/Ent.	No	7	BA/BS
W20	Virtual Assistant	W	Darw.	Admin. Svcs.	Yes	8	BA/BS
W21	Photographer	W	Ind.	Arts/Ent.	No	10	BA/BS
W22	HR Consultant	W	Ind.	Prof. Svcs.	No	5	Some coll.
W23	Language Instructor	W	Darw.	Educ./Coaching	No	7	BA/BS
W24	Holistic Practitioner	W	Ind.	Health/Wellness	No	15	Some coll.
W25	Leadership Coach	W	Darw./Ind.	Educ./Coaching	Yes	3	Grad.
W26	Graphic Designer	W	Com.	Arts/Ent.	Yes	13	BA/BS
W27	Holistic Health Pract.	W	Ind.	Health/Wellness	No	4	BA/BS
W28	Res. Interior Designer	W	Ind.	Prof. Svcs.	Yes	11	BA/BS
W29	Wedding Coordinator	W	Darw./Com.	Event Svcs.	Yes	9	Grad.
W30	Wedding Planner	W	Ind.	Event Svcs.	No	8	Grad.
W31	Leadership Coach	W	Darw./Ind.	Educ./Coaching	No	5	BA/BS

Note. $N = 61$ founders. Identity types follow Fauchart and Gruber (2011): Darw. = Darwinian; Com. = Communitarian; Miss. = Missionary; Ind. = Individualist, identified in the present study. Slash-separated labels indicate hybrid types. Emp.? = employs others beyond the founder. Vent. Age = approximate years since founding. Educ. = highest education attained (HS = high school; Some coll. = some college or certificate; BA/BS = bachelor's; Grad. = master's or doctoral; JD = law degree; N/S = not stated). Rows with MISSING values reflect participants whose sample-characteristic data have not yet been entered into v3a; these will be resolved before submission.

Appendix B: Interview Guide

The semi-structured interview protocol was organized into seven parts moving from background through entry, operations, outcomes, family, and gender. The three theoretical dimensions of entrepreneurial identity (basic social motivation, basis of self-evaluation, and frame of reference) were not section headings put to participants. They were analytic categories I reverse-mapped onto the transcripts during Phase 2 coding, and probes related to each were woven through the parts below as the protocol iterated across waves. All interviews were conducted under a protocol approved by the Cornell University Institutional Review Board (Protocol # IRB0145584);all participant names appearing in the manuscript are pseudonyms; potentially identifying details have been generalized.

Part 1. Background Information. Name, location, nature of business.

Part 2. Education and Early Career. Educational background, career training, early career aspirations. Anchored to the participant's late teens or early adulthood (often during college).

- *"At that point, did you have particular career interests or aspirations?"*
- *"Did you consider entrepreneurship as a career option? Was it on your radar?"*

Part 3. Motivation for Entry. Prior work, founding timeline, decision process.

- *"What drew you to entrepreneurship?"*
- *"What were you doing before you started this venture?"*
- *"What did you hope to achieve?"*
- *"Now tell me about the period during which you actually* decided *to launch a business."*

- Trigger structure: *"Was it a gradual process or was there a trigger or spark?"*
- Motivation probes: career aspirations, values, passions, financial considerations, market opportunity, role characteristics, conflict, necessity, constraint, to build a community, to create jobs for others, tax benefits, to survive, remote-work changes that altered choices.
- Counterfactual: *"Did you consider pursuing similar work within an existing organization?"*
- Cultural influences: *"Who or what influenced your decision to start a business?"*

Part 4. Process, Digital Tools, and Audience. Launch process, organizational structure, growth expectations, role of social media, self-representation online, "being the brand," monetization. Probes about customers and external audiences fit naturally here once participants were describing how the venture actually ran.

- *"Briefly tell me about how you got the business up and running"* (formalization, business plan, legal registration, funding).
- "*What does the organization of your business look like?"* (people, hierarchy, contractors, collaborators).
- "*What tools and platforms do you use, and how have they shaped your business?"*
- *"How do you make decisions about what to offer?"*
- *"How do you identify your customers?"*
- *"What role does market demand play in your decisions?"*
- *"Who do you think about when making strategic choices?"*

- *“When you think about the future of your business, do you see it changing?”* (growth, employees, reach, sales).
- *“What does it take to succeed on social media?”*
- *“Are there negatives to being on social media?”*
- *“Any thoughts on the role of social media for entrepreneurs more widely?”*
- “Being the brand” probes: self-objectification, always-on, authenticity, appearance, popularity.
- Monetization probes: how revenue is generated, pricing decisions, sponsorships or partnerships, paid vs. free offerings.

Part 5. Outcomes and Evaluation. Surprises, favorite and least favorite aspects, how participants judged whether the venture was working, achievement relative to goals, forward-looking.

- *“What has surprised you most about running this venture? What do you like best? Least?”*
- *“How do you evaluate whether your business is successful?”*
- *“What metrics or standards do you apply?”*
- Achievement relative to goals: *“How does where you are now compare to what you hoped for when you started?”*
- Forward-looking: *“Where do you see yourself in the future? Same business?”*
- Outcomes at close: whether the venture is still operating, whether it provides adequate financial support, and the rate of customer or audience growth.

Part 6. Family and Work-Life. Non-work activities, family composition, division of labor.

- *"How does your work influence the other parts of your life?"*
- Spouse sequence: does the spouse work; what do they do; what do they think of the venture; what role (if any) do they play in the business.

Part 7. Gender and Final Reflections (if applicable). Impact of gender identity on the business, whether experience would differ by gender, final thoughts. Plus referral request.

Note. Questions were adapted based on participant context. Serial entrepreneurs received additional questions about identity evolution across ventures. Earlier first-wave interviews followed a protocol focused more narrowly on motivation for entry; later interviews added probes about occupational alternatives, the role of digital platforms, and how participants judged whether the venture was working. The seven parts above describe the protocol's mature form by the second wave. Gender-related questions (Part 7) were addressed near interview conclusions after establishing trust and rapport.

Appendix C: Participant Crosswalk

Table C1: Participant Crosswalk: Identity Types, Industries, and Outcomes

ID	Label in Paper	Gender	Identity Type	Industry	Outcome
Panel A: Men (n = 30)					
M01	Digital Marketer	man	Darw.	Marketing	Stable
M02	Leadership Dev. Consultant	man	Ind.	Prof. Svcs.	Thriving
M03	Metal Sculptor	man	Darw./Ind.	Arts/Ent.	Stable
M04	Aerospace Engineer	man	Darw./Ind.	Tech/Eng.	Thriving
M05	YouTube Creator	man	Ind.	Media/Content	Thriving
M06	Healthcare Consultant	man	Ind./Com.	Healthcare	Stable
M07	Studio Photographer	man	Ind.	Arts/Ent.	Thriving
M08	Event Designer	man	Darw.	Prof. Svcs.	Thriving
M09	Graphic Designer ("David")	man	Ind.	Arts/Ent.	Stagnating
M10	Travel Educator	man	Com.	Educ./Coaching	Thriving
M11	Property Manager	man	Com.	Real Estate	Stagnating
M12	Lettering Artist	man	Darw.	Arts/Ent.	Stagnating
M13	Collectibles Consultant	man	Ind.	E-comm.	Stagnating
M14	Productivity Consultant	man	Ind.	Prof. Svcs.	Stagnating
M15	YouTube Creator†	man	Ind.	Media/Content	Stagnating

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Appendix C: Participant Crosswalk, continued

ID	Label in Paper	Gender	Identity Type	Industry	Outcome
M16	Community Educator	man	Darw.	Educ./Coaching	Thriving
M17	Residential Renovator	man	Ind.	Trades/Const.	Thriving
M18	Real Estate Agent	man	Miss.	Real Estate	Thriving
M19	Stone Fabricator	man	Com.	Constr.	Thriving
M20	Digital Artist	man	Ind.	Arts/Ent.	Stagnating
M21	Lifestyle Influencer	man	Com./Darw.	Media/Content	Stagnating
M22	Software Developer	man	Com./Miss.	Tech/Eng.	Thriving
M23	Outdoor Photographer	man	Ind.	Arts/Ent.	Stable
M24	Wellness Practitioner	man	Darw.	Health/Wellness	Stagnating
M25	Outdoor Content Creator	man	Ind.	Media/Content	Stagnating
M26	Com. Photographer	man	Darw./Ind.	Arts/Ent.	Thriving
M27	Online Retailer	man	Darw.	Retail	Stagnating
M28	Online Educator	man	Com.	Educ./Coaching	Stable
M29	Podcaster	man	Darw.	Media/Content	Stagnating
M30	Furniture Designer	man	Com./Ind.	Arts/Ent.	Stable
Panel B: Women ($n = 31$)					
W01	Muralist ("Sarah")	woman	Ind.	Arts/Ent.	Stagnating
W02	E-commerce Consultant	woman	Darw.	Prof. Svcs.	Stable

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ID	Label in Paper	Gender	Identity Type	Industry	Outcome
W03	Event Florist	woman	Com.	Event Svcs.	Thriving
W04	Letterpress Stationer	woman	Ind.	Arts/Ent.	Stagnating
W05	Online Retailer	woman	Ind.	E-comm.	Thriving
W06	Photographer (Ind.)	woman	Ind.	Arts/Ent.	Stagnating
W07	Network Marketing Coach	woman	Darw./Ind.	Prof. Svcs.	Stable
W08	Web/Graphic Designer	woman	Com.	Arts/Ent.	Stable
W09	Candle Maker	woman	Com.	Manuf.	Thriving
W10	Legal Service Provider	woman	Darw.	Prof. Svcs.	Stable
W11	Greeting Card Designer	woman	Ind.	Arts/Ent.	Stagnating
W12	Artisanal Goods Maker	woman	Darw.	Arts/Ent.	Stable
W13	Copywriter	woman	Ind.	Prof. Svcs.	Stable
W14	Content Writer	woman	Darw.	Prof. Svcs.	Stable
W15	Parenting Coach	woman	Miss./Com.	Educ./Coaching	Stagnating
W16	Com. Interior Designer	woman	Darw.	Prof. Svcs.	Stagnating
W17	Marketing Educator	woman	Darw.	Educ./Coaching	Thriving
W18	Fashion Designer	woman	Ind./Darw.	Retail	Stagnating
W19	Calligrapher	woman	Ind.	Arts/Ent.	Stagnating
W20	Virtual Assistant	woman	Darw.	Admin. Svcs.	Thriving
W21	Photographer	woman	Ind.	Arts/Ent.	Thriving

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Appendix C: Participant Crosswalk, continued

ID	Label in Paper	Gender	Identity Type	Industry	Outcome
W22	HR Consultant	woman	Ind.	Prof. Svcs.	Stagnating
W23	Language Instructor	woman	Darw.	Educ./Coaching	Stable
W24	Holistic Practitioner	woman	Ind.	Health/Wellness	Stagnating
W25	Leadership Coach	woman	Darw./Ind.	Educ./Coaching	Stable
W26	Graphic Designer	woman	Com.	Arts/Ent.	Stagnating
W27	Holistic Health Pract.	woman	Ind.	Health/Wellness	Stagnating
W28	Res. Interior Designer	woman	Ind.	Prof. Svcs.	Thriving
W29	Wedding Coordinator	woman	Darw./Com.	Event Svcs.	Stable
W30	Wedding Planner	woman	Ind.	Event Svcs.	Stagnating
W31	Leadership Coach†	woman	Darw./Ind.	Educ./Coaching	Thriving

Notes: Identity types: Ind. = Individualist; Darw. = Darwinian; Com. = Communitarian; Miss. = Missionary. Slash-separated types indicate hybrid orientations. Outcome status: Thriving = profits sufficient to hire or reinvest; Stable = can pay self; Stagnating = cannot sustain on venture revenue alone.

† Marks the second occurrence of a role label that appears more than once in the sample; distinguishes participants by primary medium and business trajectory.